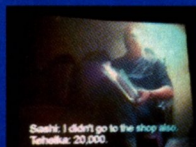


SPIN-OFFS

Dirty Deeds



Sting Operations

Undercover operations conducted by journalists and political rivals to expose corruption. With the line between entrapment and the larger goal of social good blurring the big question remains: how ethical are these stings?



Paisa khuda to nahin par khuda ki kasam khuda se kam bhi nahin (Money isn't God but, it's no less than God). So said Union minister in the

NDA government Dilip Singh Judeo while accepting a bribe. Little did he know, much like God, the camera was also invisible to him.

The Koda of Conduct

Named after Madhu Koda's antics, a reflection on the lack of ethical sense amongst our politicians.

Shoe Throwing

In 2009, a Sikh journalist threw his shoe at Home Minister P. Chidambaram in protest against CBI's clean chit to Jagdish Tytler, an accused in the 1984 riots. Tytler lost his Lok Sabha ticket and shoe throwing caught on as a tool of protest.

The Hall of SHAME

MADHU KODA The former Jharkhand chief minister is implicated in a money laundering scam of Rs 2,000 crore. He is arrested by the Enforcement Directorate on November 30.



RAJ THAKERAY The former Shiv Sainik and and his mms goons spread mayhem in Mumbai, from thrashing north Indian migrants to manhandling a legislator for taking oath in Hindi.



JAGDISH TYTLER Resigns as union minister during UPAs first term and later loses his ticket for the 2009 Lok Sabha polls following public outrage over his alleged role in the 1984 anti-Sikh riots even though the CBI had given him a clean chit.



BANGARU LAKSHMAN The then BJP president is caught on camera in a sting operation accepting a bribe and placing the bundle of notes in a drawer of his desk.



Post 26/11, much anger was aimed at politicians again. This time, I'd argue, misdirected. The urban public needed a target and they were the easiest. Foolish generalisations like they are all corrupt and thieves and criminals were really ways for the public to vent, forgetting that in a multiparty democracy, we had elected these very same people by large majorities. And could throw them out. It wasn't an us versus them because they were us, just those of us we had put in power. Once the anger subsided and ridiculous attempts at civic action from clusters of posh people died down, everybody went about their business of not voting and not caring. The tragedy and the small burst of shouting that followed did help the politicians in realising that they need to occasionally care or sound like they do, so words like "good governance" and "public accountability" became the mantras of the most recent campaigns. The interesting analysis post 26/11 that angered the media (and subsequently, the public) was how much was spent on security for a handful of VIPs while our biggest cities lay exposed to any kind of assault. One television channel asked a perturbed Murli Manohar Joshi as he walked in with his mélange of black cats, "Sir, who is paying for this?"

This decade also woke up the other end of the economic spectrum, the poorest of the poor, and not in a good way. They'd had just about enough with the India of fashion shows and DLF SEZs and zipping Mercedes. They wrote a manifesto about armed revolution, called themselves Naxals, revived a dead 70s student protest ideology and took to killing policemen and stopping trains in the deep interiors.

One party that simply by fiery speeches and obstructing regular life gained attention and political legitimacy was the MNS, with an

agenda against migrants to Mumbai, especially those from Uttar Pradesh. In a country otherwise economically powering ahead with attempts at decent government, improving infrastructure, progressive secular and liberal economic ideas with a middle class that aspired to a better life, one wondered where the MNS ideas came from. And who voted for the mandate. As the TV debates between supposed urban intelligentsia essentially became noise and screaming matches, the MNS quietly got the votes to become a party to reckon with. We realised the only thing more worrying than an agenda of malice or absent security, was us.

On a less sombre note, Shashi Tharoor, our erudite world ambassador with the foppish Oxonian Merchant Ivory charm brought the proper British accent back to Parliament reminding us that the Raj did not die; it just moved to the External Affairs Ministry and posed on the cover of *GQ*. We also found out Kapil Sibal, Cabinet minister, wrote poems (on his cellphone on long flights, like a frequent flying T.S. Eliot) whose literary merits were debated on national television. The main curiosity this aroused was what other Renaissance talents were there in the upper echelons of our ruling party? Maybe our finance minister Pranab Mukherjee was a ludo champion or our home minister P. Chidambaram made world famous lemon pudding?

So there you have it. The era that changed our lives, in brief. Winston Churchill had once said, "Indian politics is lunacy trying to reach its full potential." This decade, we came close.

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